

Chapter 46-1

As usual, Rainbow became the one left behind when no family member came to pick her up at the gate. She was already used to it.

However, as she stood there waiting for Teacher Qi Jiao, she saw Sister Liang Shi.

She originally wanted to raise her arm and call out to Sister Liang Shi, but the moment she raised her arm, she remembered that Liang Shi's niece attended the same kindergarten as her.

Rainbow thought that she probably wasn't here to pick her up.

Rainbow felt a flash of disappointment in her heart, but sheepishly lowered her hand.

She carried her pink Mickey Mouse backpack, looking at the kindergarten that had instantly become empty, lowered her head to check her phone watch, then pretended to be nonchalant as she put both hands in her pockets, her small face expressionless.

A teacher from the neighboring class glanced at her and said gently, "Rainbow, no one came to pick you up again today?"

"My mommy will come in a little while," Rainbow said.

The teacher nodded, "Then wait a bit longer."

After saying that, she left.

But Rainbow's five senses were sharper than most people's. She heard the two departing teachers whispering to each other.

"How did Rainbow get into our school? I heard her mother is just a small employee."

"I don't know either. Maybe because she's smart? Rainbow is the smartest child in our kindergarten."

"The children here have been competitive since prenatal education¹. Who isn't smart? There's a child in our class who can already recite three hundred ancient poems by heart."

"Rainbow's intelligence is different. Her comprehensive abilities are very strong. Last time I saw at Qi Jiao's place that she was already doing middle school physics problems."

"My god? Really? This is a genius."

"Yes. But she's the only one in the whole kindergarten who gets left behind. The child must feel very hurt."

"Isn't Qi Jiao taking care of her? Oh right, Qi Jiao's girlfriend looks like she's very wealthy."

"What's so strange about that? Qi Jiao was already very wealthy, right? The bags she carries are all fifty thousand yuan and up."

"Could it be that her wealthy girlfriend gave them to her? That sports car is called Fanxing Zhihai², it's over three million yuan."

"..."

The two teachers' voices gradually faded away. Rainbow lowered her head and kicked at a pebble on the ground.

She raised her arm and pressed out an international number area code, but when she got to the third digit, she deleted it all.

She couldn't call this number; Mommy would be sad.

Rainbow sighed and used her foot to kick that lonely pebble away. The pebble rolled and tumbled several times on the ground, then was kicked back by someone.

"What's a little one like you sighing about?" Liang Shi stopped in front of her, couldn't help but ruffle her head, then crouched down. "What troubles does our little Rainbow have? Why don't you tell me about them?"

Rainbow's eyes lit up when she saw Liang Shi, the corners of her mouth turned up, but she quickly suppressed it and pretended to be calm. "Sister Liang Shi, are you here to find your niece? Her class has already been dismissed."

Liang Shi looked at her and smiled gently, "No, I came to pick you up."

Children, no matter how much they pretend, can't pretend to be adults.

Undeniably, Rainbow was much smarter than other children, but essentially she was still a child.

Even more lacking in security and love than other children.

"Ah?" Rainbow tilted her head in surprise, "Have you finished work?"

"No," Liang Shi paused, deciding to tell a white lie. "I missed you, and I just happened to finish my work, so I came to pick you up from school. I'll take you to eat something delicious later, okay?"

"What about my mommy?" Rainbow asked.

Liang Shi ruffled her head again, "She's still at work, of course, working hard for our Rainbow."

Rainbow tugged at her backpack strap, "Okay."

Liang Shi asked her, "Is your backpack heavy? Do you need me to help carry it?"

Rainbow shook her head, "I do my own things myself. I can handle it."

Liang Shi gazed at Qi Jiao and Cheng Ran in the distance. The two were sitting in the sports car discussing something, seemingly having an argument. Qi Jiao turned her face away to get out of the car, but Cheng Ran immediately wrapped her arm around her waist, coaxing her in a low voice.

It looked like they were in a romantic relationship.

But based on Liang Shi's understanding of the plot and character settings, Cheng Ran wouldn't be the type to give up an entire garden for one flower.

However, she couldn't rule out the possibility of a marriage alliance between the Cheng and Qi families.

To get accurate information, she had already asked two people.

One was Liang Xinhui, the other was Zhao Xuning.

Both said they hadn't heard any news.

Liang Xinhui's response was fairly standard, while Zhao Xuning was slightly more irritable, sarcastically saying: [Are you still in contact with Cheng Ran? Tsk.]

Liang Shi: [Just happened to run into her, investigating something.]

Zhao Xuning: [Don't forget what happened before.]

Liang Shi: [Haven't forgotten, I'll make her give me an explanation.]

Zhao Xuning: [Better be.]

Liang Shi sent her a sighing-to-the-sky emoji.

Footnotes:

¹ Prenatal education (胎教): The Chinese practice of educating babies while they're still in the womb through activities like playing music, reading, etc.

² Fanxing Zhihai (繁星之海): Literally "Sea of Stars" - appears to be a luxury sports car model name in this fictional universe.

Chapter 46-2

Back then at Huayue International, Liang Shi had provided the direction, and Zhao Xuning had used her connections to investigate everything clearly.

It was Bai Weiwei who had arranged to meet with the director there to discuss business, and happened to be seen by Cheng Ran, who then used Huaguang Group's influence to pressure the director, instigating him to use Bai Weiwei's phone to call Xu Qingzhu out.

They even specifically changed their private room for them.

Originally, Bai Weiwei had booked a private room on the seventh floor and hadn't planned to stay that long.

It was the director who, following Cheng Ran's instructions, forcibly dragged it out until ten o'clock.

Even after investigating everything clearly, it was useless. Cheng Ran had disappeared from the entertainment circle for a period of time.

She was in a state where she was virtually untraceable.

Who would have thought they'd encounter each other here?

However, Liang Shi didn't plan to settle that day's score with her today. Today she came mainly to find Qi Jiao to clarify the matter about Aunt Qi.

If she didn't clarify it for even one day, she wouldn't be able to truly sever ties with the Liang family.

She wanted to know when she had come to this world.

Even if she suppressed her curiosity, she could still live in this world, but it would always be a knot in her heart.

A knot in one's heart must be untied, otherwise it would be a knot for life.

Although Liang Shi was laid-back, she never avoided problems when they arose.

The sports car with Qi Jiao and Cheng Ran was still chatting, causing even Rainbow to become curious. "Is that person Teacher Qi's girlfriend? Why does she look so fierce?"

Liang Shi turned her body around, "Little children shouldn't look."

Rainbow spoke sincerely, "If I don't look, won't it still happen?"

Liang Shi: "..."

This question left Liang Shi completely baffled.

Rainbow once again revealed her genius IQ. "They'll still fight. Human traffickers won't stop trafficking me just because I don't look. Bad people won't stop hurting me just because I don't look. Those harms exist objectively and are things I'll have to face sooner or later. Why should I avoid them?"

Liang Shi: "...?"

She never expected that one day she'd be discussing such issues with a five-year-old girl.

After thinking for a while, she said, "It's to protect you."

"Shouldn't protecting me involve letting me see more, hear more, and learn more?" Rainbow shook her head on her own. "You adults are so strange."

Liang Shi: "..."

Hey!

You're the strange little kid!

"It's because your body and mind aren't mature yet. Watching people fight doesn't benefit you in any way." Liang Shi patiently explained to her. "From the perspective of human development, children your age need to grow up in an atmosphere of love and warmth. This is beneficial for shaping your worldview¹."

After saying this, she paused, wondering if this was too profound. Would a little child understand what a worldview was?

Who would have thought Rainbow would frown, puzzled, and say, "So without an atmosphere of love and warmth, little children can't develop correct worldviews?"

Liang Shi: "..."

It had to be said that Rainbow's perspective on problems was quite unique.

Quite flavored with materialist dialectics².

So Liang Shi went on to discuss probability theory with her. She talked for a long while, and Rainbow seemed to understand but also not quite, nodding her head. "I roughly understand, but I still think not letting little children know anything isn't good."

Liang Shi: "..."

This was probably the "I understand, but I don't accept it" attitude?

Rainbow continued, "It's like how bad people prefer to target little children who don't understand anything. If little children could know more, they would be more guarded and would know that this world has both good people and bad people, instead of naively thinking everyone is good. There are still people in our class who think police officers and doctors are bad people, because when they misbehave, their parents tell them the police will take you away or the doctor will give you shots. So I think..."

She paused, then looked at Liang Shi. "You adults' educational methods all seem to have some problems."

After saying this, she even reached out to pat Liang Shi's shoulder. "Sister Liang Shi, I don't mean to attack you."

Liang Shi: "...?"

Was she just lectured by a little child?

And lectured about how to educate little children?

Liang Shi was shocked.

Before she could recover from the emotional impact of being educated by a little child, Rainbow said, "Sister Liang Shi, Teacher Qi is coming."

Liang Shi woodenly turned around, nodded slightly, and greeted Qi Jiao, "Teacher Qi."

She temporarily set aside the shock that Rainbow had given her.

"Mm." Qi Jiao didn't show any abnormality in front of the little child, gently bending down to ruffle Rainbow's head. "Today our Rainbow can go home early."

Rainbow shook her head, "We're not going home. We're going to eat something delicious first."

Her tone was calm, but Liang Shi could hear a hint of showing off.

"That's fine too." Qi Jiao maintained her gentle smile throughout. "Then our Rainbow should eat a bit more."

Liang Shi could feel that the current Qi Jiao wasn't putting on an act.

She genuinely liked the little child, and seeing the child happy made her very satisfied.

Moreover, the Qi Jiao she saw today was completely different from the one she saw at the mall that day.

When Qi Jiao was beside Aunt Qi, she was panicked, uneasy, and afraid.

But when getting along with little children, she became a different person entirely.

¹ Worldview (三观): In Chinese, this refers to one's outlook on the world, life, and values - essentially one's fundamental beliefs and moral compass.

² Materialist dialectics (唯物辯證主義): A philosophical approach that emphasizes understanding reality through material conditions and contradictions, associated with Marxist philosophy and commonly taught in Chinese education.

Chapter 46-3

Liang Shi took a deep breath and asked gently, "Teacher Qi, do you have time right now? Could we have a chat?"

Qi Jiao stood up. She was a bit shorter than Liang Shi, wearing light makeup, her long hair tied up with a yellow hair tie¹, wearing a yellow dress with a cream-colored outer jacket.

She was the type who looked completely harmless from her appearance.

When she looked at Liang Shi, she pressed her lips together, then said, "What do you want to talk about?"

Liang Shi glanced at Rainbow. Although this genius girl had just lectured her, Liang Shi still prioritized her "stubborn views" - these matters definitely couldn't be heard by Rainbow.

Liang Shi thought for a moment, "Let's pick a secluded place."

Qi Jiao refused, "Let's just talk here. There shouldn't be anything that others can't hear."

Liang Shi looked around - there weren't many people left anyway.

Just some teachers who were gradually leaving.

Liang Shi called to Rainbow, "Could you go wait in the car for me? I have something I want to discuss with your teacher."

Rainbow looked at her watch, "How long?"

Liang Shi: "..."

She thought about it, "No more than ten minutes."

If Qi Jiao didn't cooperate, it might not even take three minutes.

Liang Shi unlocked the car and watched Rainbow get in, even telling her there was an iPad in the back seat with some science fiction movies downloaded that she could watch freely.

Rainbow carried her backpack and didn't look back, but when she reached the roadside, she looked both ways to check for oncoming vehicles.

When Liang Shi withdrew her gaze, she found that Qi Jiao was still watching Rainbow.

It wasn't until the car door closed and Rainbow made an "OK" gesture from inside the car that she turned around, lightly pressing her lips together, her expression returning to coldness. "Miss Liang, I don't think we have anything to discuss."

"You and Mrs. Qi." Liang Shi said, "The President Qi from Qida Company - you're family, right?"

Qi Jiao frowned and asked back, "What about it?"

Liang Shi exhaled lightly, "I often have a dream where Mrs. Qi appears, and you appear too."

By the time she said this, Qi Jiao's face had already changed.

Her originally rosy cheeks instantly turned pale, "You... what do you mean?"

She immediately shook her head, "I've never seen you before, I don't know you."

Liang Shi smiled slightly, "Really? When we were children, we never met?"

"No!" Qi Jiao answered decisively without a moment's hesitation, "I don't know anything."

Liang Shi saw that her state was unstable and took half a step back, maintaining a safe distance.

"We did meet, didn't we?" Liang Shi spoke gently, trying to let the other person feel her goodwill.

"In that dim little room, your mother didn't just hit you..."

"Sorry, I don't know what you're talking about." Qi Jiao's eyes showed panic, but she quickly interrupted her. "I don't think we need to have this conversation. You won't get the answers you want."

Liang Shi sighed softly, still maintaining her gentle voice while comforting Qi Jiao, "Don't get agitated. This makes me think you're the little friend who experienced those things together with me."

"I'm not, you've got the wrong person." After Qi Jiao finished speaking, she turned to leave, but Liang Shi grabbed her wrist.

"Miss Qi, I heard from Ling Dang that you're still suffering those torments now, is that right?" Liang Shi adopted a roundabout strategy. "I didn't come to reminisce about the past with you. I just heard Ling Dang mention some things, so I wanted to come chat with you."

"Thank you, but I don't need it." Qi Jiao refused.

Then she glanced at her hand, "Please let go of me."

"Don't you want to know how the other little child who was abused is doing now?" Liang Shi asked, "That sister you forced to speak."

"I told you, I don't know you." Qi Jiao said, "I have no memory of the things you're talking about."

"Then why are you so agitated?"

"..."

Qi Jiao suddenly fell silent.

She closed her eyes, "What answer do you really want?"

Liang Shi looked at her, then asked, "Has your mother always been like this?"

Qi Jiao said, "No comment."

"Teacher Qi." Liang Shi smiled gently while loosening her grip on her wrist. "What I want to say is, the way to deal with domestic violence is to become stronger, not to submit passively. That way you'll just keep getting bullied."

Qi Jiao remained silent.

The evening breeze gently swayed the treetops, and vast expanses of fire clouds² appeared on the distant horizon, dyeing half the sky red.

The remaining sunset glow spread everywhere, and slightly yellowing leaves spun as they drifted down from above.

A leaf happened to land on Qi Jiao's shoulder.

Liang Shi reached out and gently brushed it off for her.

"Sister Qi Jiao." Liang Shi used the address from twenty years ago, and even her smile curved exactly the same way as before. "Enduring it won't make things keep getting better."

Qi Jiao suddenly widened her eyes, tears filling them.

"You really don't know anything." Qi Jiao smiled slightly, "So what do you want to do now? Have me help you testify in court about childhood events?"

"No, I just came to verify something." Liang Shi said, "Now I've already gotten the answer I wanted."

Footnotes:

¹ Hair tie (大腸圈): Literally "large intestine ring" - a colloquial term for scrunchies/hair ties because of their resemblance to sausage links.

² Fire clouds (火燒雲): A poetic term for the red/orange clouds that appear during sunset, literally meaning "fire-burning clouds."

Chapter 46-4

Liang Shi only wanted to know whether that was a dream or reality.

Now Qi Jiao's reaction proved everything.

Next, it would be a matter between her and Qiu Zimin.

However, as fellow victims, Liang Shi still wanted to encourage Qi Jiao. "If parents become demons, then they don't deserve to be called parents. You don't have to keep enduring - that will only make the demons become even more brazen."

Qi Jiao looked at her, her brows slightly furrowed, as if deep in thought.

"Also," Liang Shi said, "when you're in love with Cheng Ran, keep some reservations. Don't love too completely."

People who have been abused easily fall into love, but often end up being hurt beyond recognition by love again.

Qi Jiao didn't answer her words.

After a long while, she asked, "Do you really think you've successfully escaped?"

Liang Shi smiled, "Not yet, but someday I will succeed, right?"

Her hopeful gaze struck Qi Jiao's heart like a heavy blow.

"The first step of resistance is strengthening your inner self," Liang Shi said. "She might not be able to beat you now."

"I'm working my way out. Perhaps, you can watch me. If one day I need someone to testify in court, I hope you can come, because this isn't just my matter - this is something we experienced together."

Liang Shi's voice was gentle, deliberately lowered to a warm and lingering tone. Although it was autumn, it made people feel like spring breeze was blowing, carrying hints of spring vitality and vigor.

As if what she said was real, achievable.

"Of course, I'm not morally blackmailing you," Liang Shi said. "You can be afraid, you can retreat - these are all understandable. But I hope you can be brave."

Qi Jiao's tears fell with the wind.

Liang Shi said, "Let's be brave together."

Under her highly persuasive tone and rhetoric, Qi Jiao suddenly smiled. That smile was like a withered flower at the end of autumn, carrying hints of decay and desolation. "But what if I said that Qi Jiao has already..."

The words stopped abruptly halfway through.

That half sentence "died" got stuck in her throat.

Liang Shi asked gently, "What?"

Reason returned.

Qi Jiao raised her hand to wipe away her tears, "Nothing."

She took a deep breath and once again erected high walls, shutting Liang Shi out. "I'll pretend I never heard what you said. You should go."

Liang Shi didn't press further either.

Whether it was her own experience or the original owner's experience, both made her feel fear the moment she remembered, the moment she saw Mrs. Qi.

Qi Jiao had always lived in such an environment - how could she possibly not be afraid?

She understood Qi Jiao's cowardice and respected her choice.

Liang Shi just hoped she could find her way out.

Could be a little braver.

Say no to domestic violence.

"Teacher Qi," Liang Shi said, "I'm sorry for making you recall some unpleasant memories, but I don't regret today's conversation. I hope you can think about it carefully too."

"The little girl has grown up. We can protect others, but the first person we should protect is ourselves."

At this moment, Liang Shi's tone was more like a kindergarten teacher than Qi Jiao's.

Coaxing and cajoling.

It had to be said, this was still effective.

Qi Jiao fell into contemplation.

As she said goodbye to Qi Jiao and turned to leave, Qi Jiao suddenly called out to her, "Miss Liang."

Liang Shi turned around, her smile gentle, more fervent than the fire clouds on the evening horizon. "Mm?"

"Su Yu's mother isn't called Su Yao," Qi Jiao brought up another matter. "Her mother is called Su Mu, from a single-parent family."

Footnotes:

¹ Worldview (世界觀): One's fundamental beliefs about the nature of reality, values, and how the world works.

Chapter 46-5

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When Liang Shi returned to the car, Rainbow was concentrating intently on watching a movie.

She fastened her seatbelt, started the car, and casually asked Rainbow what she wanted to eat.

Rainbow thought for a moment, "Can we have hamburgers?"

Liang Shi: "..."

Why did all little children like to eat fast food?

But adults generally didn't want little children to eat it.

Yet Liang Shi had no way to resist Rainbow's longing gaze, so she made an agreement with her that she could only eat hamburgers and fries, but couldn't drink cola, as it would stunt her growth.

The car drove away from the kindergarten entrance. Liang Shi had just turned on the car stereo, planning to play some music, when the prelude had been playing for less than five seconds and they reached an intersection where a car suddenly pulled out.

No turn signal, no horn honking either.

It wasn't even turning - it simply pulled out to force Liang Shi to stop.

Fortunately, Liang Shi was driving slowly. Even so, she still couldn't brake in time and crashed into it.

There was only a slight impact sensation at the front of the car.

Liang Shi's entire body lurched forward, scaring her so much her heart nearly stopped.

She herself didn't matter much, but there was a five-year-old child in the back seat!

When Liang Shi saw clearly what car it was and who was in it, she angrily slapped the steering wheel, unfastened her seatbelt and was about to get out. But before getting out, she instructed Rainbow, "No matter what happens, don't get out of the car."

Rainbow had figured out the rules of this world very thoroughly. Zhou Li, after accepting her high IQ, had probably taught her a lot of knowledge that peers her age didn't need to know.

"Should I call the traffic police?" Rainbow asked.

Liang Shi said, "Not for now."

If she called the police... how could she beat someone up?

She got out of the car aggressively, untied the hair tie from her wrist, and quickly tied her hair into a ponytail in a few swift motions.

Cheng Ran had also gotten out of her car and was standing in front of it lighting a cigarette. Her brown wavy long hair danced in the wind, making her look utterly charming.

She looked at Liang Shi and smiled with curved lips, "Long time no see."

"Yes," Liang Shi flexed her fingers, "We almost didn't get to see each other at all."

If she had been driving just a bit faster, she'd need to call 120¹ right now.

She had reasonable suspicion that this was her predicted disaster involving bloodshed.

But she planned to transfer this disaster to someone else.

"You now..." Cheng Ran looked her up and down, "You've really changed a lot."

"Of course," Liang Shi said. "After leaving bad company and changing circles, naturally I'm much cleaner."

Cheng Ran: "..."

Cheng Ran sneered coldly, "You're really good at pretending, Liang Shi."

"Not bad," Liang Shi said coldly. "But not as good as you."

Originally she didn't want to cause trouble in front of the little child. Even if they encountered each other, she had planned to settle the score next time they met.

But now Cheng Ran was acting like a mad dog.

A car crash?

There was a five-year-old child in there!

Footnotes:

¹ Hair tie (大腸圈): Literally "large intestine ring" - slang for scrunchies/hair ties due to their resemblance to sausage links.

² 120: China's emergency medical services number, equivalent to 911 ambulance services in other countries.

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Liang Shi's anger burned fiercely in her heart. "Cheng Ran, are you crazy? If you want to die, go jump off a building, drink poison, drown yourself, or jump off a cliff - no one will stop you. Stop harming other people."

"A small car accident can kill someone?" Cheng Ran laughed. "Third Miss Liang, aren't you being too precious? Besides, didn't you lose your memory? Maybe a good crash would knock it back into place."

Liang Shi frowned, closed her eyes, clenched her fists, and while Cheng Ran was still laughing, threw a punch at her.

Before transmigrating, she used to work out and had practiced kickboxing and Muay Thai.

Although the original owner's body was weak, after so many days of her persistence, running five kilometers wasn't a problem.

So this punch she threw was much heavier than the one Cheng Ran had given her back then.

Cheng Ran was caught completely off guard by the punch. She raised her head and said viciously, "Liang Shi, are you fucking crazy?"

"That's my line back to you." Liang Shi threw another punch as she spoke. Cheng Ran raised her arm to block it, but couldn't block Liang Shi's other arm. Her movements were fast, accurate, and ruthless - she was putting real force behind them.

"I haven't settled the score with you for what happened last time." After punching her three times, Liang Shi closed in on her. "The grudge between you and me - if you have the guts, come at me directly. What kind of skill is it to mess with my wife?"

After being hit, Cheng Ran was initially angry, but now she was laughing with rage.

She curved her lips in a smile, "What? Are you angry?"

Her smile was extremely asking for a beating.

So Liang Shi couldn't hold back and gave her another punch, hitting her until blood flowed from the corner of her mouth.

Cheng Ran wiped the blood from the corner of her mouth, "Liang Shi, that's about enough."

"Same words back to you." Liang Shi repeated this phrase again, then sneered coldly. "Cheng Ran, if it had just been me alone in my car today, this matter would be settled. But there's a little child in my car. No matter how much of a piece of trash you are, don't touch children."

Liang Shi was truly angry.

She stared coldly at Cheng Ran, "Also, for matters between us, come find me directly. Stop messing with my wife."

"The Huayue International incident." Liang Shi said, "I know all about it."

"Do you know who the real mastermind behind it was?" Cheng Ran revealed a crazy smile.

Liang Shi frowned and didn't respond.

After a few seconds of silence, Cheng Ran laughed, "You came to find me without knowing anything. Liang Shi, you're still as reckless as ever. So why should bad people learn to become good? It's so difficult."

"I'm just being a normal person," Liang Shi said. "Perhaps you'll never understand that in this lifetime."

"Mm, you're so noble." Cheng Ran sneered coldly. "No matter how much trash I am, I wouldn't stoop to messing with your wife. We were friends once - you can't even figure out who's actually harming you. That's pretty pitiful."

"Zhou Yi'an?" Liang Shi raised an eyebrow questioningly.

Almost the moment Cheng Ran said the words "real mastermind," this name popped into Liang Shi's mind.

Seeing Cheng Ran's expression now confirmed it.

Cheng Ran: "Not completely stupid after all."

"But you're still an accomplice." Liang Shi threw another punch at her as she spoke.

All of Cheng Ran's resistance was like scratching an itch through a boot¹ against her.

How could someone who had been constantly immersed in wine and revelry be her match?

So in this fight, Liang Shi emerged completely unscathed.

By the end of the beating, whenever Cheng Ran saw her move, there was fear in her eyes.

After Liang Shi released her, she asked, "Are you unconvinced?"

Cheng Ran scoffed lightly, "Fuck you."

"We can have a competition," Liang Shi said. "Horseback riding, archery, racing, dice - if you win, I'll apologize to you. If you lose, go apologize to Xu Qingzhu and take responsibility for your actions."

Cheng Ran initially refused, thinking she was crazy.

The former Liang Shi wasn't good at any of the above activities and was always the loser in friendly competitions.

But now she was brazenly talking about one-on-one challenges, which was simply laughable.

However, Liang Shi said, "If you don't want to compete, that's fine too. Just go apologize to Xu Qingzhu directly."

"Impossible."

After a long while, Cheng Ran stared at her and asked, with a hint of coldness in her eyes, "Are you serious?"

Liang Shi nodded, "Yes."

Cheng Ran's fingers caressed the Fanxing Zhihai car body. After thinking it over, she asked, "Liang Shi, after we compete, we really won't be friends anymore."

There was still some attachment in her tone.

Liang Shi said, "We stopped being friends long ago. In fact, from the moment you messed with my wife, we became enemies."

Cheng Ran was speechless, "Is Xu Qingzhu really that important?"

"Would I have married her if she wasn't important?" Liang Shi threw the rhetorical question back at her, then asked, "Will you compete or not?"

Cheng Ran: "..."

After an unknown amount of time, Cheng Ran said, "Let's compete in archery."

Footnotes:

¹ Scratching an itch through a boot (隔靴搔癢): A Chinese idiom meaning ineffective action that doesn't address the real problem, like trying to scratch an itch through your shoe.

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The archery rules were that both parties would wear helmets with apples placed on top.

They would see whose aim was more accurate, who could shoot the apple.

The face-covering part of the helmet was transparent.

This method had a very high difficulty level.

It was a game the original owner and Cheng Ran used to play when they fooled around together to torment people.

Although the person being tormented knew the arrow wouldn't actually hit their face, they were still afraid - what if it hit their body?

Liang Shi chose their former shared entertainment activity to end this game.

She brought Rainbow along too, but just had her wait in the car.

Then she would fight a quick battle.

Archery was Cheng Ran's specialty. She had already won the silver medal in the Haizhou City youth archery competition in middle school.

The original owner, as a spoiled waste who couldn't do anything, knew nothing.

But Liang Shi had previously filmed period dramas and played a female general.

Other actors might use stunt doubles, but Liang Shi had earnestly learned archery for three months.

She had trained her arm strength to the extreme - modern bows, ancient bows, she could hit the bullseye every time.

On the vast, boundless grassland, streetlights lit up one after another.

The sky was covered with a layer of deep blue, and in the night curtain were bits of starlight.

To end things quickly, Liang Shi chose a single round to determine the winner.

Cheng Ran even gave her a chance to back out, mocking her naivety.

Had she really lost her memory and thought she could do anything now?

She had even forgotten what her best friend used to be best at.

But Liang Shi told her to fight quickly and decisively.

The moment the helmet was put on, Liang Shi's gaze became sharp, like an unsheathed sword.

She and Cheng Ran looked directly into each other's eyes.

Liang Shi asked her, "Do you keep your word?"

Cheng Ran scoffed lightly, "I'm not so low as to break promises with you."

Liang Shi curved her lips in a smile, "Then that's fine."

Between casual conversation and laughter, the arrow had already left her hand. The arrow that swiftly left the bowstring pierced through the wind.

At the same time, the arrow in Cheng Ran's hand also departed.

Two arrows converged in mid-air.

Neither of them moved, standing straight in place.

But when the arrow pierced through the wind and was only a step away from her, Cheng Ran couldn't help but fearfully step back half a pace, her head also slightly shifting.

Then came a "thud" sound.

The sharp arrow pierced through the apple on her helmet.

Meanwhile, her arrow barely grazed past Liang Shi's right side. After encountering resistance, it slowed down and finally fell to the ground.

Liang Shi removed her helmet and said confidently and generously, "You lost."

Cheng Ran asked in disbelief, "Why? You actually didn't dodge? You used to dodge every time before."

Liang Shi smiled slightly, "A gentleman's wager, a gentleman's agreement."

She looked at Cheng Ran and repeated, "You lost."

Cheng Ran closed her eyes, her expression complex.

She never would have thought that she would lose in her most prideful skill, and lose to Liang Shi of all people.

But this was the event she had chosen herself, the venue she had picked herself.

She had also calculated based on Liang Shi's weakness.

But she hadn't expected that Liang Shi wouldn't even blink, neither avoiding nor yielding.

Cheng Ran clenched her fists, then relaxed them.

"A bet is a bet," Cheng Ran said.

Liang Shi placed her helmet on the ground, "I hope to see your sincere apology."

Chapter 46-8

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By the time Liang Shi brought Rainbow to eat hamburgers, it was already past 8:30. She felt deeply sorry.

Moreover, Zhou Li had already returned home, so when Liang Shi sent the child back, she was surprised.

Liang Shi had originally wanted to tell the truth, but Rainbow covered for her, "Sister Liang Shi took me to see a movie."

Liang Shi: "..."

She went along with the excuse Rainbow had given her.

When Liang Shi passed by the road leading to Xu Qingzhu's company, she sent Xu Qingzhu a message asking if she had gone home yet.

Xu Qingzhu's reply was very brief: [I'm back.]

So Liang Shi drove home.

The living room lights were on, and the smell of food wafted from the house.

Liang Shi suddenly felt at peace in her heart.

But unexpectedly, as soon as she walked over, Xu Qingzhu came out of the kitchen, "What did you do today?"

Liang Shi: "...Helped a colleague pick up a child after work."

"You seem to particularly like little children," Xu Qingzhu said casually.

Liang Shi was startled, "It's... it's alright."

She did like them a bit.

Mainly because human cubs each had their own charm.

Ling Dang was sweet-talking and good at coaxing people, while Rainbow was the cool type but exceptionally considerate.

"Besides picking up the child?" Xu Qingzhu asked her.

Liang Shi hesitated, not knowing whether she should tell Xu Qingzhu about Cheng Ran and Qi Jiao.

Xu Qingzhu was exceptionally patient with her. After asking, she kept waiting for her answer, so there was no way to brush it off.

After a few seconds, Liang Shi said, "I also went to find Qi Jiao. Regarding childhood matters, she denied them, but judging from her attitude, it should be true."

"So what do you plan to do?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi thought for a moment, "I'll go back to the old mansion tomorrow."

To see Qiu Zimin.

Even if she only had to listen to those disgusting words.

She had already researched PUA¹-related materials. What Qiu Zimin had done to the original owner was definitely PUA.

PUA and abuse by parents toward their children would actually be typical Stockholm syndrome².

The children would become especially dependent on their parents and expect to gain their recognition.

They were essentially suffering abuse, but wanted to gain the abuser's approval.

Qiu Zimin was really skilled at manipulating people's hearts, and she even used feudal superstition³.

Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu had the same thoughts - those formations wouldn't really do anything to her, but living long-term in such a depressing environment would drive a person insane if it didn't kill them.

But why was Qiu Zimin doing this?

Liang Shi planned to go back to the old mansion tomorrow to play dumb and fish for information.

"Cheng Ran contacted me today," Xu Qingzhu suddenly said. "She apologized to me and said she'd come apologize in person another day."

Liang Shi stopped thinking about the Liang family matters and answered somewhat frantically, "...That's good news."

Xu Qingzhu looked at her with determined eyes, "You did that, didn't you?"

Liang Shi: "...Huh?"

Xu Qingzhu took out her phone and showed it to her, "Unfortunately, all your whereabouts today were exposed."

Liang Shi: "?"

She looked at Xu Qingzhu's phone with complete bewilderment.

First were photos of her and Qi Jiao standing at the kindergarten entrance, taken quite ambiguously, especially the scene where she reached out to brush the leaf off Qi Jiao - it looked particularly like they were about to embrace.

Several photos showed her and Qi Jiao standing together.

Then there were photos of her and Cheng Ran, showing her throwing punches at Cheng Ran with a somewhat fierce expression.

Especially her eyes - she herself hadn't realized her gaze could be so stern.

Liang Shi pressed her lips together, "Do I have the right to explain?"

Xu Qingzhu put her phone away. She hadn't shared the text messages Bai Weiwei had sent her with Liang Shi.

She only showed Liang Shi the pictures.

The text messages Bai Weiwei had sent were: [The person you've chosen is nothing special after all.]

[She's deceiving you. What do you mean she's changed for the better?]

[Look at how she hits people - how is that different from before?]

[They're all trash.]

Xu Qingzhu had already deleted those messages.

She only kept the pictures.

Xu Qingzhu smiled as she looked at her, "What do you want to explain?"

Liang Shi: "..."

After silence, she found that she actually didn't know where to start explaining.

But Xu Qingzhu shrugged and turned toward the kitchen, "Let's eat."

Liang Shi: "...?"

This wasn't right.

Xu Qingzhu brought out the dishes, then looked at the completely bewildered Liang Shi. Her clear, cold voice carried a hint of tenderness, "Teacher Liang, who sought justice for me, you've worked hard."

Footnotes:

¹ PUA: "Pick-up Artist" tactics, but in Chinese internet culture often refers to psychological manipulation and emotional abuse techniques used to control someone.

² Stockholm syndrome: A psychological phenomenon where hostages develop positive feelings toward their captors.

³ Feudal superstition (封建迷信): A term used in modern China to describe traditional beliefs and practices considered backward or unscientific, such as fortune-telling, feng shui used manipulatively, etc.